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BLOCK 5 QUALITATIVE METHODS

As explained in Block 1 of this course, the major difference between the quantitative approach and qualitative approach is not the type of data used or preferred but is much broader and deeper. The quantitative research is associated with positivist and post-positivist paradigm whereas qualitative research is associated with interpretative paradigm and critical theory paradigm.

Notwithstanding with the debate about quantitative research vs. qualitative research, a researcher may use either quantitative methods or qualitative methods or mixed methods blending the techniques of the two. In Block 3 and 4 we have covered various quantitative methods of data analysis. In this block you will find the qualitative methods exclusively associated with interpretative paradigm and critical theory paradigm. This block comprises of 3 units.

Unit 18 on Participatory Method throwing light on the limitations of the methods to collect quantitative data either through primary survey or secondary sources covers the various tools and techniques used in collection and analysis of qualitative data under participatory method and its advantages.

Unit 19 on Content Analysis deals with the conceptual and methodological issues related to content analysis as a research method to undertake research studies in social sciences in general and in economics in particular.

Unit 20 entitled **Action Research** throws light on Action Research as an offshoot to emancipatory method associated with critical theory paradigm wherein knowledge is generated in the process of knowing through doing rather through conceptualization and theorizing. This unit covers the various models of action research and the different steps involved in conducting action research.

UNIT 18 PARTICIPATORY METHOD

Structure

- 18.0 Objectives
- 18.1 Introduction
- 18.2 What is Participatory Research?
- 18.3 Methods of Participatory Research: Observation Method
 - 18.3.1 Participant Observation
 - 18.3.2 Non-Participant Observation
 - 18.3.3 Quasi-participant Observation
- 18.4 Focused Interview
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- 18.6 Life History
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 - 18.10.1 Data Sources and Sampling
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- 18.11 Analysis of Qualitative Data
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- 18.13 Criticism of Participatory Methods
- 18.14 Advantages of Participatory Research
- 18.15 Let Us Sum Up
- 18.16 Key Words
- 18.17 Some Useful Books/Readings
- 18.18 Answers or Hints to Check Your Progress Exercises

18.0 OBJECTIVES

After going through this Unit, you will be able to:

- state the concept of participatory research;
- state the distinction between data collection and data generation;
- explain the various tools of participatory research;
- discuss the grounded theory as a method of inductive theorising;
- identify the various steps involved in the analysis of qualitative data;
- pinpoint the major criticisms against participatory methods; and
- draw the lessons for participatory researchers.

18.1 INTRODUCTION

As discussed in Unit 6, traditionally two approaches – quantitative research associated with post positivist paradigm and qualitative research associated with interpretative paradigm have been followed in undertaking research in social sciences. The researchers working in the area of economics (both in micro and macro) generally rely upon the inferences drawn from the large pool of data. The data for these studies are collected either by the data compiling agencies or by the individuals hired for data collection without involvement of individual researchers in the field. The results of such quantitative research are insensitive to context and ignore the people's voices or their views about which studies have been undertaken. Instead researcher's opinion is imposed on what people say and want. The collection of quantitative data through sampling survey and its analysis involving several steps is time consuming. In the situation of natural calamities and disasters like tsunami, we cannot wait for the outcome of quantitative research. Further, quantitative research has not been very effective in evaluation of poverty alleviation schemes and programmes. In such situation, alternative method i.e. participatory method is increasingly being used in social sciences to generate and analyse the data.

Hence, in this unit, we shall take up the various issues related to participatory methods like concept of participatory research, the various tools to collect qualitative data, analysis of qualitative data, advantages, limitations and important lessons for participatory research etc. Let us begin with explanation of the concept of participatory research.

18.2 WHAT IS PARTICIPATORY RESEARCH?

The fundamental premise of participatory research involves the direct participation of researcher in the process of data generation. Important distinction is made here between data collection and data generation. When data is collected by an agency on large sample populations, standardizations are made with the assumption that all those being interviewed will understand and respond to the questions in the manner in which the primary researcher has conceptualized it. In the field situation this may or may not be the case. Each field researcher asking those questions may convey a different meaning and the respondent may give answer that may not fit into any of the standard categories, but the field researcher will reduce the answer and fit it in any of the given categories in a structured schedule. Hence, the results obtained may not necessarily reflect the market sentiments or the opinion of the people involved in the study. It is for this reason that this process of procuring data using survey method and questionnaire is called data collection.

In participatory research, the primary researcher is always in contact with the respondent and has a face-to-face interaction. If the researcher thinks that the respondent has not understood the query, he has the freedom to change the language or reconstruct his probe question or collect information from other indirect source. In this approach called **data generation**, the researcher has the flexibility to generate multiple answers to a single query and then use his/her interpretative skills to draw inference or meaning out of it to arrive at a generalization. In participatory method of data generation, the process of data

collection and analysis proceeds simultaneously, making it more reliable and presenting plurality of responses and possibilities. It is this flexibility and its ability to generate reliable generalizations that participatory methods of research have acquired importance in research methodology being used by present day economists.

Let us first try and understand what participatory research is and how and where it began? Methods of participatory research first find mention in anthropological empirical research commonly known as ethnography. Ethnography is defined as a method used to generate qualitative data from an insider's perspective known as **EMIC view**. In simple terms it implies that the people about whom we are writing, must tell their stories and the researcher simply interprets them as “thick description” (Geertz, 1973). People's voices are critical to research instead of researcher's imposition of his opinion on what people say and want.

18.3 METHODS OF PARTICIPATORY RESEARCH: OBSERVATION METHOD

Bronislaw Malinowski is regarded as the founding father of this methodology. He described this method as “participant observation”. He stayed for more than three years among the “Trobriand Islanders” and described their lifeway's in a classic ethnographic work titled *Argonauts of Western Pacific* first published in 1922. Methods of participatory research in the last ninety years or more have been defined and redefined in many different ways. Malinowski's method of participant observations demands the researcher's stay in the field area for prolonged periods and become a part of the society that he/she is researching. Later researchers realized that it was always not possible to stay for extended duration (from three months to three years and in some cases even longer) in the field and some problems can require immediate and urgent interventions. Another critique of participant observation is that an interviewer is always an outsider and even when he lives at a particular field site for long periods, there is no guarantee that the community will view him as an insider and share every aspect of their private lives with the researcher.

Nonetheless, none of these limitations influenced the importance of using observations as one of the most important tools of participatory researches. Balki (2009:206) calls it as “qualitative method par excellence”. Bryman (1998, 47-9) puts forward a case for method of observation by saying that it is not a single method but can combine several ways of doing observations. Given the significance of method of observation, the techniques went in for some modifications. There are three important ways of doing observations that are now recognized: (i) Participant Observations, (ii) Quasi-Participant Observations, (iii) Non-Participant Observations.

18.3.1 Participant Observations

Uncontrolled Participant observation is defined by Goode & Hatt (1981: 121) as a procedure in which “the investigator can so disguise himself as to be accepted as a member of the group”. When researchers live at a field site for long duration, the assumption is that they are regarded as member of the community or the group. A researcher wanting to study consumer behaviour may not disclose his identity as a researcher and pretend to be a consumer, sharing their experiences

and concerns. While doing participant research, researchers often assume insider identity. Sometimes researchers take neutral positions without disclosing the real purpose of their being there.

Advantages of Participant Observation Method

Researcher can record all the information relevant for his work without disturbing the community and intruding upfront into their privacy. Instead of sitting in a corner in the market, an organization or any other work or field situation writing notes, the researcher participates in these activities. In doing so, he collects relevant information without disturbing the normal activities and records his observations in a work diary. Thereafter, he makes a mental note of it and returns to his/her workplace and records these observations immediately. The community or people may not be aware that they are being researched. This helps obtain unhindered and unbiased information.

Participant observation helps to obtain detailed information without any subject bias. Many researchers regard it as a better tool for data gathering vis-à-vis questionnaire and in-depth interviews.

Drawbacks of Participant Observation Method

One of the major drawbacks of participant observation is its inability to develop procedures for standardization. Researcher doing participant observation acquires a specific position in the community and observes from this vantage point. His recordings are personal or individual specific. Another observer observing the same situation may not be able to view it with the same perspective.

In participant observation method, the researcher may get emotionally involved with the issues and tends to lose his/her objectivity. This often happens on issues of dowry, bride burning, female foeticide, student agitations, price rise, public-private partnership, trade union activities etc.

To overcome some of these drawbacks, researchers proposed method of non-participant observations.

18.3.2 Non-Participant Observation

The qualitative researchers innovate in several ways to do non-participant observations. Many of them would participate in some activities and observe others from the outside. Some others would use video- recordings and analyse these recordings later for generalizations. While doing so, it was possible to take into account people's gestures and non-verbal movements for detailed scrutiny. However, critics of the method thought that as one is not fully participating in this situation, he/she is not in a position to attribute right meaning to these observations.

Sometimes, researchers use hidden cameras and record individual observations separately. But there are several problems with this method of observations too. Many regard use of hidden camera for research unethical. Participating in some activities and not in others amounted to what researchers later called as Quasi-participant observation.

18.3.3 Quasi- Participant Observation

Most researchers these days prefer to use quasi-participant method of observations. In this method, the researcher can follow the dual entry system. For instance, if you are trying to examine labour management relations, it is imperative that you obtain permission from the management and also establish rapport with the trade union leaders to have access to the union meetings. Many a times, one has to conduct interviews in different locations. In one such study in Punjab and Uttar Pradesh, we found that the workers preferred to talk to the researcher outside the factory. The researcher would talk to the managers and supervisors in the factory and had lunch in the workers canteen. Appointments were fixed with the workers while having lunch and then researcher went to their houses, often spent hours there and after completing the interviews with the supervisors and managers hired a small room in the same slum area, where most of the workers lived and shared their daily experiences.

In addition to the important research tool of observations, qualitative researchers often use Focused interview, in-depth interviews, narratives and oral /Life case histories, Focus group discussion/interviews', and content analysis. These tools have been discussed in next sections.

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) What is the distinction between data collection and data generation?

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- 2) What do you mean by the term EMIC view?

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- 3) How is participant observation method different from non-participant observation method?

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18.4 FOCUSED INTERVIEW

In a focused interview, the researcher and the respondent are engaged in face-to-face or one to one conversation in which the researcher poses questions and the respondent provides detailed or precise answers. Talking to people or a specified group of people selected randomly, using an interview schedule, interview guide or a structured questionnaire is standard method of data collection. For qualitative

research, focused interviews are often unstructured and questions are invariably open ended. This gives the respondent liberty to provide extensive answers.

It is important to remember that interview is “fundamentally a process of social interaction” and involves developing a social relationship. In an interview situation it is not only the interviewer but also the interviewee who makes an opinion about the researcher. Respondent’s responses can be determined by what he thinks what the researcher may expect from him and also the amount of trust and faith he invests in the researcher. We will repeatedly stress the importance of confidentiality and researcher’s ability to convey the same as hallmarks of participatory research.

18.5 ORAL HISTORIES

Uninterrupted long interviews giving space to the respondents to express his opinion or experiences at length is the preferred method by several qualitative researchers. The interviewee is encouraged to share his life experiences, to express his opinion, to recollect and recount their antecedents or lives of their contemporaries, “and to discuss their perceptions of the processes involved and the changes they have seen”(Balki, 2010:207). Collecting oral histories or narratives requires skill of being a good listener. Many a times, you may assume that the information provided by the respondent is not directly related to the area of your focused interest. But that subsidiary information can provide certain reference for a better understanding of the problem, issues or question that you are exploring. In oral histories, one may pose probing questions in the beginning and then occasionally intervene to ask a lead question for seeking any detailed answer to specific query.

18.6 LIFE HISTORY

Another important tool that ethnographic and qualitative researchers have in their kit is called the life history method. In this method life histories of individuals are reconstructed to understand the historical events of that period. Many a times researchers would use diaries and autobiographies to construct chronology of events of that period. Recording experiences of individuals facilitates understanding of how and what happened in certain circumstances. Life history approach is largely dependent on the ability of the respondent to recall and share that memory with the researcher. With the help of the respondent, researcher gradually determines the social processes. In the context of economics, rise and fall of a particular model is determined by prevalent social processes of that period, e.g. popularity and weakening of models of conservative and liberal economics in the last fifty years. It also helps to understand different perspectives based on gender and class. While recollecting their life history, many a times respondents may fall silent. This silence also provides data as it tells the researcher, how that particular event may have caused anxiety, anguish or an intense emotional experience to the respondent.

18.7 CASE STUDY METHOD

To study firms and organization’s behaviour, Business economists use the case study method. The researcher can focus on one company or organization and